

and history, and especially to know who incorporated it in this narrative, whether the Chronicler or some later hand. And this necessarily involves the further question, whether the original language of this episode—or, rather, the language in which it stood at the time when it was incorporated—was Semitic or Greek. If it never existed in Semitic form, then it certainly never was inserted by the Chronicler in his own book, nor could it ever have formed a part of any Semitic recension of these narratives of the Jewish exiles. On the other hand, if it can plausibly be maintained that the Greek text of the story, as we have it, is a translation from the Hebrew or Aramaic, then we have at hand the solution of some of the chief problems in this literary tangle.

It is fortunately possible to decide at once the question as to the Chronicler, while holding the question of the original language still in abeyance. The form of this history contained in I Esdr., chaps. 2-5, cannot possibly have been the form given it by its author. So scholars of all times have agreed, with hardly a dissenting voice, and for reasons that are conclusive. In the first place, the Artaxerxes correspondence, 2:15-25 (= Ezra 4:6-24), is palpably misplaced here. It constitutes, to be sure, a very good introduction to the Story of the Three Youths, which immediately follows, but forms in no sense the continuation of 2:1-14, where the narrative is obviously cut short in the middle. Again, the Story of the Youths is itself a disturbing element, and the disturbance this time is far more serious. The presence of this story inevitably turns the whole history upside down, bringing in contradictions and absurdities from which there is no escape. To mention only a single point: The events narrated in 5:46-70 [47-73] (notice verses 53 [55], 68 [71], and 70 [73]!) *are events of the reign of Cyrus*, even in this recension! There is no way of making them anything else, or of supposing that they were ever written in any other way. It is not easy to believe that any compiler of a serious history could make such an outrageous blunder as this. What is more, the episode of the Youths cannot be made to fit in anywhere else. Whoever tests the matter will speedily find that there is no point, before, in, or after Ezra 1-6, at which this episode is a possibility; at that, too, even if the name of the king be changed from "Darius" to some other name. Removed to any other place, it causes even greater disturbance than it makes at present.